argued that, while the ancient Hindu practice of ‘pushing women into their husbands’ funeral pyre was condemnable, there was nothing wrong if a woman wanted to commit sati voluntarily’.[129] For Scindia, who led a pro-sati march in 1987 after the infamous burning of Roop Kanwar, a widow in Rajasthan’s Deorala, sati was ‘very much part of our tradition’.[130] She argued in the Lok Sabha that voluntary widow self-immolation was no different from self-immolation by some DMK workers in Tamil Nadu after the death of their leader M.G. Ramachandran.

The BJP, which had condemned ‘sati’, quickly distanced itself from Scindia’s position. Yet, in many ways, this debate reflected the chasm between the party’s long-held notions of patriarchy and tradition and its aim of attracting women voters.[131] The internal contradictions were highlighted again in 1994 when Sushma Swaraj officially condemned the Shankaracharya of Puri for his public opposition to women chanting Vedic verses. At a time when there was a deep disquiet over the Hindu Right’s positioning on women, Swaraj declared that, for the BJP, ‘anything attributed to scriptures or any practice followed which denigrates the position of Indian women deserves outright rejection’.[132] This tension between the party’s ambitions for the women vote and the patriarchal notions of some of its members was a constant through the 1990s. On the one hand, the Mahila Morcha would hold a rally comparing its women workers to the angry Hindu goddess Chandika.[133] On the other, there would be headlines such as the one made by Mridula Sinha, then president of the BJP’s Mahila Agadi, when she blamed women for domestic violence. ‘Yes, it’s often the woman’s fault,’ she declared. ‘She can provoke the man to such an extent that he beats her. And sometimes the woman can be so *ziddi*. We tell the woman to try and adjust. After all, it is her family.’[134] At one point in the late 1990s, Sangh leaders in Delhi were even saying that girls should not wear skirts, ostensibly because mosquitoes would bite their legs.[135] Until the early 2000s, instances like these confirmed for many liberals that the BJP and the wider Sangh Parivar subscribed to regressive patriarchal notions that were at odds with modern values like individual agency.